he wrote in his memoirs. ‘So following the Holy Quran’s recommendation of mercy, and the dictates of our own mild and forgiving nature, and recognising that humankind is a compound of mistakes and carelessness, we listened favourably to his excuses and granted him our royal pardon, trusting that such disloyal behaviour would not occur again.’[40]

So it was that Mahmoud was put under house arrest in the palace at the top of the Bala Hisar. This policy backfired badly when in 1808 Shah Mahmoud managed to escape and join forces with Shuja’s greatest enemies, the rival Barakzai clan. The feud between the two clans, the Barakzais and the Sadozais, was already bitter and bloody, and was soon to cause a conflict that would ravage the whole country, dividing the tribes and providing a range of opportunities for the neighbouring powers to intervene. Before long it would become the central conflict of early nineteenth-century Afghanistan.

Payindah Khan, the patriarch of the Barakzais, had been wazir – prime minister – to Shuja’s father Timur Shah. He was the king-maker responsible for bringing Shah Zaman to power on Timur’s death in 1793. He had initially been a loyal wazir, but after six years the two had had an angry disagreement.[41] A few months later, the Shah discovered that his Wazir had been plotting a palace coup to protect the interests of the old nobility. Shah Zaman then made the mistake of murdering not just the Wazir to whom he owed his throne but all the ringleaders, most of whom were senior tribal elders. Shah Zaman compounded this by failing to secure any of the Wazir’s twenty-one sons. Far from neutralising the Barakzai threat, Shah Zaman had effectively kicked a hornet’s nest. By starting this blood feud between Afghanistan’s two leading families, he opened a fracture in the Afghan political class that would soon widen into the chasm of a civil war.

The eldest of the Wazir’s sons was Fatteh Khan, who took his father’s place as the head of the Barakzais. But it gradually became clear that the most determined and threatening of the Barakzai boys was a much younger brother by a Qizilbash wife, named Dost Mohammad Khan. Dost Mohammad was only seven years old and working as the Wazir’s cupbearer when he saw his father executed in court, and the horror of the event seems to have marked him for life.[42] He grew up to be the most dangerous of all the enemies of Shah Shuja and by 1809, at the age of seventeen, was already a ruthless fighter as well as a canny and calculating strategist.